EXHIBITION

The Civility of **Disobedience**

A new exhibition and accompanying book capture the way the original disruptors in Mumbai helped pave the way towards freedom for India

AD 1930-1931, a year in the past, which impacted not only the present at the time, but has had far-reaching effects into the future. This was when anti-colonial protests gained a firm foothold in India, starting with Mahatma Gandhi leading the march to Dandi against the taxation of salt and, ultimately, leading to a mass mobilisation of ordinary citizens from all walks of life, as they became actively involved in the struggle for freedom from the British yoke. This phenomenon manifested especially strongly in Mumbai, with women participating as actively as men... making and selling salt when it was against the law; spinning yarn on charkhas so families could wear Indian-made khadi; encouraging people to buy swadeshi goods; and being fearless at the forefront of public protests.

Evidence of these small acts by everyday nationalists that led to significant consequences for the country can be viewed in the latest exhibition, titled *Disobedient Subjects: Bombay, 1930-1931,* at Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Vastu Sangrahalaya (CSMVS), on till March 31, 2026. Through rare archival photographs, historical objects and works by artists such as Homai Vyarawalla, Atul Dodiya and Uzma Mohsin, the exhibition, curated by Avrati Bhatnagar and Sumathi Ramaswamy, captures the moods and moments that helped the Civil Disobedience Movement in India to achieve the scale it did.

Rare photographs, historical objects and works by artists *CAPTURE THE MOMENTS* of the Civil Disobedience Movement

Sabyasachi Mukherjee, director general, CSMVS, speaks about the K.L. Nursery album, acquired by the collaborating Alkazi Foundation for the Arts over two decades ago, which provides a detailed visual record of Mumbai's transformation into a city of collective defiance. A few of the 245 photographs from the 1930s from this album are included in a book released as a complement to the exhibition. Titled *Photographing Civil Disobedience, Bombay 1930-31* and published by Mapin Publishing and the Alkazi Collection of Photography, it features nine enlightening essays and gritty photographs around the anti-colonial protests, and a preface by Rahaab Allana, curator, Alkazi Foundation. In tandem with the exhibition, it offers a unique perspective on the average Mumbai citizen as a disruptor for positive change. An inspirational legacy that remains relevant today. ■

—Priya Pathiyan





FRAMES OF FREEDOM A procession of the Mohammedans of Bombay in sympathy with their Hindu brethren; right, women and children prepare salt from the sea water at the Congress house, 1930